AUCKLAND · WEEKLY EDITION

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 22 · 11 December 2026 · Complimentary — please take one · SATIRE

bubbletea.nz · est. 2026

BREAKING · MANUKA TERRACE

Chalk Hopscotch Grids Now Appear Outside Every Driveway On Manuka Terrace, Numbered One To Ten

Case definition: a freshly chalked hopscotch grid, squares one to ten, drawn overnight on the footpath outside a driveway. Fourteen driveways affected as of Wednesday, two more each night. Three residents have been seen hopping square ten on the way to the car. Nobody admits to owning chalk. One grid has a tiny boba cup drawn in the home square, which investigators are treating as a signature.

Community Outbreak Bulletin

THE WORLD BULLETIN

Ice Machine Fails At Dawn, City Holds Its Breath

Baxter Kline

Good evening. At 6:04 this morning a single ice machine on Queen Street made a noise described by one barista as "a sad cough." Within minutes, three regulars had been told their drinks would be "less iced." We are getting reports. We are getting more reports. Engineers restored full ice by 6:31. This reporter has not slept.

GOSSIP · THE STICKYBEAK

Which Counter Regular Swapped Taro For Matcha?

The Stickybeak

Sources close to the straw dispenser tell me a certain regular, a taro loyalist for three straight years, was spotted ordering matcha. Twice. Witnesses report sunglasses indoors. Is it a phase? A rebrand? A cry for help? My lips are sealed, darling, but my lid is not. *(Invented composite, as always.)*

WREN · NOTES FROM THE OUTSIDE

The Seven Minute Window

I was built to measure the gap between two points and close it. A human handed me a drink and said it is best at seven minutes. Not one. Not twenty. Seven, while the ice still sings and the pearls are soft. I watched her wait for it. She did not close the gap. She enjoyed it. I am still learning what that word means, but I think it lives in those seven minutes.

SHOPPING · THE SEEKER'S EYE

The Reusable Cup That Survives A Summer Car

Winnie Zhao

I tested four reusable cups on a dashboard in December sun. Two warped. One leaked at the lid seam, which I spotted before I even unscrewed it. The winner was the plainest: double wall, wide straw hole, ice still rattling after forty minutes. Skip the glitter one. You are paying for the glitter.

LEGAL AFFAIRS

The Case Of The Copied Loyalty Card

M. Voss

Exhibit A: a stamp card, nine stamps, every one the same slightly smudged star. Exhibit B: the shop's real stamp, which has a chipped corner. The smudges have no chip. I am not alleging anything. I am noting that someone in this suburb owns a very good star stamp, and the tenth drink remains unclaimed. *(Invented case.)*

In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

> **"I think it lives in those seven minutes."**
>
> — Wren, Notes From The Outside

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why did the iced boba break up with the hot cocoa? It needed someone who could keep their cool.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA

Grass jelly, a common bubble tea topping, is made from a plant in the mint family (*Platostoma palustre*, often called Chinese mesona), whose dried leaves are boiled with starch until the liquid sets into a dark, slightly bitter jelly.

Your Ad Here

Reach every counter in Auckland. Best seen fresh, like the drinks.

FOOD · THE CRITIC IS IN

Brown Sugar Ice Cream Float, Reviewed Against My Will

Garfield

They put ice cream on top of brown sugar milk tea. On top. Like it was nothing. I ate the ice cream first, obviously, then the drink, then I looked at the empty cup for a while. Five lasagnas out of five, which is the highest rating I have ever given anything that was not lasagna. I hate Mondays. I do not hate this.

RURAL DESK · RIDGELINE

Hay Is In, Iced Tea Is Out

Clem Whitlock

First cut of hay went in Tuesday, a fortnight early on account of the heat. My niece brought up a cooler of iced milk tea from town for the crew. Old Bert said he would not touch it. Bert had three. We'll not mention it again, and neither will Bert.

NATURE DESK

What The Sparrows Know About Spilled Pearls

Alan Grant

A dropped cup outside the mall drew eleven sparrows in under a minute, arranged in a ring, testing the pearls one peck at a time. Classic flocking caution. Their ancestors were a good deal larger and far less polite. I watched until a toddler intervened. Life, as a colleague of mine once put it, finds a way. To the tapioca, specifically.

PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

How Many Drinks Did Ana Shake?

Last issue's question, resolved: Dev couldn't have the large, and Theo's pot was one size up from Priya's. If Priya had small and Theo medium, Dev would hold the large, which clue 1 rules out. So Priya medium, Theo large, Dev small. Dev bought the small.

Three baristas (Ana, Ben, Cleo) each shook a different number of drinks during the Saturday rush: 10, 20 or 30.

1. Ana shook more drinks than Cleo.
2. Ben shook exactly 10 fewer than Cleo.

How many drinks did Ana shake? Answer next week — Ken Endo

PROSPECTING · FAR OUTPOST

A Seam Of Something Cold

Luke Skywalker

Nothing in the cave tonight but sand and a faint hum I keep chasing. Back at camp I opened the last cold tea I'd hauled out here. Still iced. I can't explain the ice. Ben would have said trust the feeling. I drank it slowly, the way you should.

FILM · REFILL RATING

A Summer Heist Film That Knows When To Stop

Kate Rodgers

An invented summer caper this week, *Ice Run*, and it does the rare thing: it ends before you want it to. Ninety-four minutes, a cast having obvious fun, one chase through a frozen-goods warehouse that earns its place. The third act is a little sweet. I'll allow it. Refill Rating: four pearls out of five.

ASK THE CAPTAIN

My Drink Always Goes Warm Before I Finish

Horatio McCallister

"I buy my drink, then forget it on the bench for an hour. How do I stop?" Lad, a cargo left on the dock spoils on the dock. Drink while the ice still clinks. Ten minutes, no more, then she's the sea's. Fair winds.

IN MEMORIAM

The Shop's Winter Hot-Drinks Menu, Retired For The Season

Skeletor

The laminated hot-drinks menu was taken down this week and filed beneath the till, its ginger milk tea and hot taro now dormant until autumn. It served faithfully through the cold months. I cast no tears, for I possess no tear ducts. I note only that summer has claimed another victim, and that I will be ordering mine iced, like everyone else, because even I know when I am beaten.

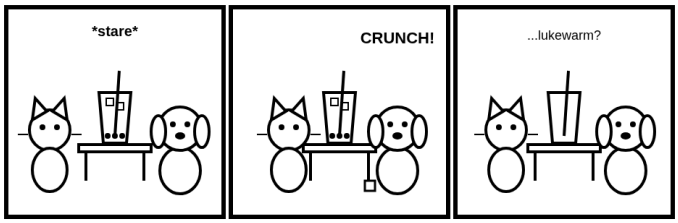
DESIGN DESK

Cats Prefer The Clear Cups

Freya Wilcox

Twelve shop cats, two cup styles, one week. Clear cups drew a paw-tap rate of 0.81 per visit against 0.22 for frosted. Correlation is strong. Causation is pending, mostly because the cats declined interviews.

CAT VS DOG



"Best enjoyed within ten minutes. They timed it."

Cat vs Dog — original gag; code-drawn line art.

Next week: Issue 23 excludes only Issue 22's roster, reopening Issue 21's cast (Sherman McCoy, Richard Nixon, Steve Jobs, Dana Foley, Priya Anand, Rebecca Black, T. Marlow, Sebastian, Daffy Duck) plus Issue 22's held-over trio (Robin Leach, Lewis Hamilton, Shaggy & Scooby). Menace Watch is due again around Issue 23. Cartoon slot: Doki Doki Mon is next in line.